

Lesson 10: Reading Critically

Analyze claims, evidence, and sources.



 In this activity, you will read a short article about substance use and practice **evaluating the claim**, identifying the **evidence**, and **judging the source's credibility**.



Understanding Critical Reading

When we read about health topics, it is important to think carefully about the information. Authors often try to persuade readers, so we must look past the surface to see if the message is true and fair. By using **critical thinking**, you can become a smart consumer of information.

Concept	Explanation
Claim	The main point or 'big idea' an author wants the reader to believe.
Evidence	The facts, statistics, or expert opinions used to support the claim.
Credibility	The quality of being trusted or believed, often based on the source's background.



Read the Following Text

Read the text below carefully. As you read, **ask yourself**: What is the author trying to convince me of, and what information are they using to support that goal?

The Truth About Energy Drinks

Many students reach for energy drinks to stay awake during long study sessions. However, it is time to rethink this habit. Energy drinks often contain extreme levels of caffeine and sugar that can be harmful to a developing body. Recent studies from a blog called 'EnergyFast-Life' suggest that energy drinks are the best way to boost focus. The author of the blog states, 'I drank three cans a day and felt super energized!'

Doctors have a different perspective. Many pediatricians warn that high caffeine intake can cause heart palpitations, anxiety, and sleep issues for middle schoolers. Research published in the *Journal of Adolescent Health* shows that students who avoid these drinks perform just as well on tests as those who drink them. Protecting your heart and your sleep is more important than a temporary caffeine buzz. Focus on drinking water and getting plenty of rest instead.



Answer the Questions

Please **answer** the following questions using specific details from the reading.

1. What is the main claim the author is making about energy drinks?

[Write your answer here.]

2. What specific evidence does the author provide to show that energy drinks might be harmful?

3. How would you describe the evidence provided by the 'EnergyFast-Life' blog? Is it reliable? Why or why not?

4. Why might a reader trust information from the *Journal of Adolescent Health* more than a personal blog?

5. Based on the text, why is it important to evaluate different sources before making a health decision?

